

Introduction

The prosody-pragmatics interface

This special issue contains 12 papers, all of which address the interface between prosody and pragmatics. The collection is the outcome of a conference held in Preston in November 2003, hosted by the University of Central Lancashire and the North West Centre for Linguistics, and sponsored by the Linguistics Association of Great Britain and the British Association of Academic Phoneticians. The aim of the issue is to illustrate the role that prosody can play in the interpretation of pragmatic meaning, including both emotive and social meanings. The papers represent a variety of theoretical approaches, from Relevance Theory to Conversation Analysis, and refer to a wide range of prosodic phenomena, both phonological and paralinguistic, categorical and gradient.

The vocal resources that are collectively known as *prosody* include four main components: pitch, loudness, tempo and voice quality, the most studied being pitch, or intonation. All these can characterise an entire utterance or a single syllable: a stretch of speech can be loud or soft, fast or slow, high or low, and spoken with a tense or breathy voice. Such variation is gradient rather than categorical, and is generally assumed to convey natural (paralinguistic) meaning. The same prosodic components also serve to create a prosodic system, a coded and therefore to a large extent arbitrary pattern of sounds. Intonational phonology (see [Ladd, 1996](#)) has been the focus of much experimental work in the last two decades, its main aim being to show that intonation has a phonological organisation. This assumed distinction between natural and linguistic meaning is challenged, however, by the paper contributed by *Wilson and Wharton*, who argue that some phenomena which have been assumed to be grammatically encoded can be analysed as natural phenomena (see also below).

A common assumption is that the prime function of prosody is expressive, i.e. to convey mainly emotions and attitudes rather than any referential meaning. This suggests that prosody/intonation is a kind of paralinguistic overlay on an utterance whose referential meaning has already been identified by other means. However, as the papers in this special issue show, prosody can also contribute to the identification of utterance meaning. While some papers are concerned with continuously variable parameters, such as relative pitch range, others focus on the role that phonological choices can play in conveying meaning. The choice of a rise or fall, or the placement of a pitch accent, may be as important a cue to speaker meaning as its phonetic realisation. The introductory article by *House* provides a systematic overview of the prosodic resources available for utterance interpretation, and, assuming a strongly inferential model of communication, shows how Relevance Theory can be applied to relatively recent innovation in British English—the ‘high rise tone’ or ‘high rise terminal’.

Prosody plays an important role in many languages in the structuring of information within discourse, by lending psychological salience to certain syllables, and manipulating rules in order

to indicate broad and narrow focus. If discourse can be seen as a cognitive process rather than as a spoken or written text, the role of prosody is to adjust or maintain the accessibility of referents. Current models of discourse accessibility and referential expressions focus almost entirely on morpho-syntactic features, while the papers in this collection focus on prosodic features. The simple view is that prosody lends prominence or non-prominence, but this is not the case. Discourse accessibility is reflected not only in where an accent occurs but also in the kinds of contours chosen. The degree to which accessibility and its prosodic encoding is language-specific is controversial (see *Wilson and Wharton*, this volume) and it is the subject of several papers in this collection, which examine the role of prosodic prominence in Spanish, German, Greek and English.

Labastia's study is a comparison of Argentinean and mainland Spanish. He claims that Relevance Theory predicts that focus naturally occurs finally, and that any non-focal final material will be interpreted as predictable. Spanish is said to keep the focal accent at the end even if it occurs on predictable (old) information, although this is usually avoided by syntactic restructuring. Argentinean Spanish, on the other hand, seems to be able to defocalise final constituents in a manner similar to that described for English. *Baumann and Grice's* study of German is based not on a binary distinction between given and new but takes account of recent notions of a givenness hierarchy or degrees of accessibility (*Ariel*, 1990; *Gundel et al.*, 1993). The authors, however, follow *Chafe* (1994) in assuming not a continuum but three categories of accessibility: given, new, and an intermediate status—information that is 'accessible', i.e. reactivated from a semi-active state. They define accessibility in terms of whether it is textually, situationally or inferentially accessible. Most importantly, they assume that accessibility is not only indicated by presence or absence of prominence (accent), but by different types of accent. They present results of a perception experiment which suggest that the intonation of accessible information depends on the nature of the semantic relations between the antecedent and the referring expression.

Current models of referent accessibility differ in their assumptions as to whether there is a one-to-one or one-to-many relationship between accessibility and coding (*Siewierska*, 2004). *Baumann and Grice* (above) found no one-to-one relationship between prosodic coding and accessibility category. *Baltazani* in her study of Greek, discusses models of information structure categories in question and answer sequences, and she, too, finds no one-to-one relationship between prosody and information structure. In a study of it-clefts and wh-clefts in English, based on the London Lund Corpus, *Collins* finds four related factors that determine the pragmatic properties of the structures, and suggests that the newness or givenness of information is indicated not by prosody but by discourse-recoverability.

An interesting application of the study of focus to the semantics-pragmatics interface is found in *Ashby's* paper, which considers the role of focus in spoken idioms. Ashby shows that a literal use and idiomatic use of the same utterance can be indistinguishable, but that a change in accent placement can effectively destroy the idiom, thus highlighting the non-compositional (non-literal) part of the idiom in question. In addition to fixed accent placement, Ashby considers the fact that some idioms appear to be fixed in their choice of nuclear tone or contour. Here he claims that the apparent fixedness is related not to the inherent fixedness of the idiom but to the normal function of such idioms, for instance as exclamations (e.g. I could eat a horse!), and it is this status as exclamation that determines the tone choice.

Within speech act theoretic approaches to pragmatics it is assumed that the identification of the speech act communicated by an utterance is a prerequisite of successful communication (but see *Sperber and Wilson*, 1995, for a critique). This raises the question of how speech acts are

identified, and in particular, what linguistic means are used by speakers to indicate the intended force of their utterance. The paper by *Meyer and Mleinek* examines an interesting case where focus marking potentially interferes with the marking of utterance force in Russian. Their study, based on both production and perception experiments, raises interesting cross-linguistic issues.

The role of prosody in the expression of non-referential meaning – for example, affective and interpersonal meaning – is well-known, but the mechanisms by which this is conveyed remain elusive. Studies of the relationship between emotions, attitudes and prosody have so far failed to show any direct effects (*Stibbard, 2001*), despite common assertions that, for example, wide pitch range may indicate greater emotional involvement than narrow pitch range. Some studies in experimental phonology have successfully elicited listener judgements on the relative ‘friendliness’ or ‘assertiveness’ of isolated utterances, but there are a number of phoneticians, particularly those working primarily on naturally occurring speech, who reject such an utterance-based approach. A study by *Wichmann and Cauldwell (2003)*, for example, showed that the judgements of the affective value of naturally-occurring utterances varied considerably depending on whether they were heard in isolation or in context. The most systematic approach to the study of meaning in its interactional context is that of Conversation Analysis (CA). This approach, unlike Gricean pragmatics or Relevance Theory, rejects an utterance-based model and sees meaning as sequentially constructed between participants. Evidence based on post hoc evaluation by listeners is rejected in favour of that based on the behaviour of participants themselves.

Ogden’s contribution in this volume is representative of the Conversation Analytic approach. In his discussion of agreement and disagreement sequences in conversation he shows that the stance being expressed is indicated relationally, in other words by the phonetic and prosodic patterns of one utterance in relation to another. This challenges recent attempts to construct an underlying coded meaning associated with high and low pitch—Gussenhoven’s ‘biological code’ (*Gussenhoven, 2002*), and supports the view that interpersonal and affective meanings are created by the relationship between utterances rather than by the inherent properties of an individual utterance. The same relational effects are observed by *Kooij et al.* in their paper on the prosodic signalling of focus in Dutch Sign Language. They describe how movements of the upper body and head are used in the realisation of ‘corrective focus’. While there seems to be a clear use of body lean for this purpose, the direction of the lean cannot be completely equated with denial or affirmation. Instead, it appears to depend on the direction of leans of both participants in the preceding discourse. The meaning thus appears to be constructed sequentially across turns rather than being an inherent property of a single turn. The authors raise the interesting question of whether these movements are in fact unique to sign language, or whether similar body positions occur in conjunction with speech.

The collaborative construction of meaning is applied by *Curl et al.* to the prosodic correlates of interaction management, using the same CA framework, focussing on participants’ interpretation of pragmatic meaning and the sequential organisation of talk. In their paper they show that phrasal or clausal repetitions can be used collaboratively to close a sequence, and that when this occurs, the repetitions display a constant relationship to one another in terms of pitch range, pitch direction and duration.

Wilson and Wharton also consider interpersonal and affective meanings, but in contrast with the interactional approach of the conversation analysts, their paper is an attempt to reconcile such meanings with pragmatic theory. Traditional approaches to pragmatics, in their view, exclude ‘natural’ meaning (emotional or attitudinal effects which are not intentionally communicative), and, moreover, focus on propositional or conceptual meaning. Accordingly, they argue that the

challenge raised by prosody for pragmatics is twofold: first it must identify the sense in which some affective or attitudinal vocal effects may be expressed with an intention to communicate; and second, it needs to accommodate the fact that the kind of meaning conveyed cannot be expressed in terms of a particular propositional content. In order to meet the first challenge, the authors argue that prosodic inputs must be distinguished according to whether they are natural signs (which are non-communicative), or natural signals (which are inherently communicative). Thus, some vocal effects such as affective or attitudinal tones of voice have been selected for communicative purposes, in the same way as, for example, smiles. Second, they accommodate the non-propositional nature of prosodic meaning by analyzing it in terms of ‘procedural’ meaning (Blakemore, 1987, 2002), whose function is to constrain the range of possible interpretations of an utterance, rather than to contribute to its content.

All the studies described so far in this collection presuppose a hearer’s ability to ‘read’ speaker meaning. However, it has been observed that autistic hearers often appear to lack this ability. The study by *Peppe et al.* investigates pragmatic competence from a clinical perspective, describing a test designed to assess the communicative functions of prosody, including the affective function, the delimitation (chunking) function, the discourse function (e.g. turn delimitation) and its focalizing function. The test, as is shown by means of a detailed case study, is able to indicate a measure of pragmatic deficit, and the role that prosodic skills may play in this. As prosodic deficit is not currently addressed by speech and language therapists, this is an important contribution to clinical applications of the prosody-pragmatics interface.

Prosodic meanings, whether in terms of phonological categories or their phonetic realisation, are at best extremely general, but as Ladd (1996:39) points out, “these meanings . . . are part of a system with a rich interpretative pragmatics, which gives rise to very specific and often quite vivid nuances in specific contexts.” We hope with this collection of papers to have exemplified a range of approaches, varying in their underlying views of language and of communication, and consequently employing different methodologies. Each has its strengths and limitations, but all share the aim of showing how prosody contributes to our understanding of pragmatic meaning. We hope that this collection will lead to further collaboration between researchers in the fields of prosody and pragmatics, and that this will result in an enriched understanding of the relationship between prosody and pragmatic meaning.

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